

Ichthyosaurus

The skull found by Mary and her brother belonged to a sea creature known then as a “fish lizard.” It lived around 200 million years ago and was sold to a collector for £23—more than £1,800 (\$2,400) in today’s money.



Mary even came up with a way to figure out what ancient animals ate by studying coprolites—their fossilized poop!

Fossil hunter extraordinaire

Mary spent the rest of her life hunting for fossils in Dorset. By reading, she became an expert on rocks and the way animal bodies fit together. This allowed her to extract fossilized bones without breaking them, then piece skeletons together like 3-D jigsaw puzzles to figure out what these prehistoric animals looked like when they were alive.

Other leading paleontologists traveled to Dorset to learn from Mary, and they used her discoveries to inspire or support new ideas. Gradually, fossils completely changed the way we think about the Earth and every living thing on it.

The Jurassic Coast in Dorset is still an amazing place to hunt for fossils from dinosaurs.



The best time to find fossils is after storms, when chunks of the cliffs have smashed to the ground. It can be dangerous work, and in 1833, falling rocks killed Mary’s beloved dog, Tray.

Plesiosaur

In 1823, Mary discovered a fossilized plesiosaur skeleton—she was the first person to find one! This “sea dragon” was more than 13 ft (4 m) long, with a long neck like a giraffe and flippers like a sea lion.